PEDAGOGY + AI · GRADES 6–12 · FREE PRINTABLE PACK

Retrieval Rhythm

Start every lesson with students answering from memory, mixing last lesson, last month and last term. About ten minutes of preparation a week.

Your weekly rhythm

After each lesson · 1 min
Add a row to your log: the date, the topic and two or three key points.

On Friday · 5 min
Paste the log into the prompt and copy it into your AI tool.

Before Monday · 3 min
Check the answer key, especially anything under CHECK.

Why it works

Retrieval practice Strong

Practice testing is one of two strategies rated high utility in the best-known review of study techniques (Dunlosky et al. 2013). Meta-analyses of classroom studies confirm it improves learning in school (Yang et al. 2021; Ruitenburg et al. 2026), across ages and subjects (Agarwal, Nunes & Blunt 2021).

Spacing Strong

Distributed practice is the other strategy rated high utility by Dunlosky et al. 2013. A 2026 meta-analysis of studies in real school classrooms finds a small but reliable benefit from spacing practice out (Ruitenburg et al. 2026), and a 2022 review finds that spacing and retrieval together give the most durable learning (Carpenter, Pan & Butler 2022).

Interleaving Promising

A meta-analysis finds a moderate overall benefit from mixing categories during practice. The benefit is strongest for paintings and other visual material, small for maths and unclear for texts, and blocking actually worked better for learning words (Brunmair & Richter 2019). A 2026 meta-analysis of school classroom studies finds a similar average benefit (Ruitenburg et al. 2026). Mixing helps most when students must tell similar things apart.

Misconception-based options Promising

Multiple-choice questions with plausible wrong options work as retrieval practice, not just as a test (Little et al. 2012). When the wrong options are built on common misconceptions, the answers also show the teacher what to re-teach, which is the idea behind hinge questions in formative assessment.

STARTER FORMAT · 5 MIN

Starter quiz

Five short questions answered from memory before anything else happens.

1. Questions on the board as students come in. No notes, no books.
2. Three minutes to answer, then students check and correct their own answers.
3. Ask who got each question right, and re-teach what most missed.

Name _____ Date _____

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

5. _____

6. _____

Score: ___ / ___

STARTER FORMAT · 5 MIN

Brain dump

Students write everything they remember about one earlier topic, then compare.

1. Name the topic. Students write everything they remember for three minutes.
2. Pairs compare and add one thing they missed in a different colour.
3. Show the key points. Students tick what they had.

Name _____ Date _____

Topic:

Write everything you remember. Then add what you missed in a different colour.

STARTER FORMAT · 7 MIN

Retrieval grid

Nine questions from different weeks, worth more points the further back they go.

1. Students answer as many questions as they can, in any order.
2. Older content earns more points, so it is worth trying the hard row.
3. Go through the key. Note which row the class found hardest.

Name _____ Date _____

Last week 1 point			
2–4 weeks ago 2 points			
Older 3 points			

Total points: _____

STARTER FORMAT · 5 MIN

Multiple choice with misconceptions

Four options per question, where every wrong option is a common misunderstanding.

1. Everyone answers at once: fingers, cards or mini whiteboards.
2. Look at which wrong options are popular. Each one shows a misunderstanding.
3. Re-teach the most common misunderstanding before moving on.

Name _____ Date _____

1.

◯ A ◯ B ◯ C ◯ D

2.

◯ A ◯ B ◯ C ◯ D

3.

◯ A ◯ B ◯ C ◯ D

4.

◯ A ◯ B ◯ C ◯ D

STARTER FORMAT · 3 MIN

Two things I remember

Students name two things from one earlier lesson and one question they still have.

1. Name the lesson. Students write two things they remember.
2. They add one question they still have about it.
3. Read the questions. They show you what to recap.

Name _____ Date _____

Lesson:

1. One thing I remember:

2. Another thing I remember:

A question I still have:

FOR STUDENTS AND PARENTS

Why we start every lesson like this

Most lessons now begin with a few questions answered from memory, without notes or books. Some questions are about last lesson, some about a few weeks ago, and some about last term.

Why from memory?

Every time you pull something out of memory, it becomes easier to find again. Reading your notes again feels useful, but it helps much less than trying to remember first.

Why old topics too?

We forget quickly. Coming back to a topic after a few weeks, just as it starts to fade, makes it last much longer than practising it many times in one go.

Why does it feel harder?

It is supposed to. A quiz feels harder than listening to a recap, and that effort is exactly what makes it stick. Getting an answer wrong is part of it: the starter is practice, not a test, and it shows us what to go over again.

How you can help at home

Ask: "What did you have to remember at the start of the lesson today?" Trying to explain it once more is another round of practice.

Your own prompt

Fill in the blanks, then type the prompt into any AI tool: Copilot, Gemini, ChatGPT or Claude. Leave out the line "First lesson" if you do not need dates. Faster online: the builder at choosewise.education/retrieval-rhythm fills this in and lets you paste your log.

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Do not include student names or student results in this conversation.

You are helping a Grade _____ _____ teacher plan retrieval practice
starters for next week. Use only content from the topic log below. Do not add new content.

Format: _____ (the format's name, and its line from the list
below)
Number of lessons: _____
First lesson: _____
Questions per starter: _____ (for starter quizzes and multiple choice)

Topic log (date, topic, key points):
_____
_____
_____

In starter quizzes and multiple choice, mix content from different times in the log: about
two fifths from the most recent lessons, two fifths from two to four weeks earlier, and
one fifth from older entries. Count the weeks back from the newest entry in the log. If
the log is short, spread the questions across all of it. Mix the order so students cannot
tell which week a question comes from. The other formats follow their own description.

Reply in plain text, no tables. For each lesson write:
LESSON: the lesson number, the format, and the log entries it draws on, with their dates
STARTER: the starter exactly as students will see it
KEY: the answer to every question
Then once, at the very end:
CHECK: every answer you are not fully sure of, one per line, so the teacher can verify it.
Write "None" if there are none.
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Mix. Use a different format for each lesson, chosen from these five: starter quiz (short questions from memory, each with one clear answer); brain dump (students write everything they remember about one earlier topic for three minutes; the KEY lists the key points); retrieval grid (nine questions in three labelled lines: last week 1 point, two to four weeks ago 2 points, older 3 points); multiple choice with misconceptions (options A to D, where every wrong option is a common misconception; the KEY names it); two things I remember (students write two things from one named earlier lesson and one question they still have).

Starter quiz. Short questions answered from memory in about five minutes. Each question has one clear answer: a word, a name or a sentence.

Brain dump. Name one earlier topic from the log. Students write everything they remember about it for three minutes, then compare with a partner. The KEY lists the key points to look for.

Retrieval grid. A grid of nine questions in three rows: last week (1 point), two to four weeks ago (2 points) and older (3 points). Write it as three labelled lines, not as a table.

Multiple choice with misconceptions. Questions with four options, A to D. Every wrong option is built on a common misconception about this content. The KEY says which misconception each wrong option shows.

Two things I remember. Name one earlier lesson from the log by its date and topic. Students write two things they remember from it and one question they still have. The KEY lists what a full answer would mention.